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6.2 How to Help International Students Explore Community Colleges in the US

Focus Questions:

- *What are three reasons a community college might be a good fit for an international student?*
- *Could a community college be the only institution an international student would attend in the US (i.e., without transferring to a four-year college?) Why?*

Online Resources

Resources include:

- The AACC's **Community College Finder**
- The **Community College Review**

If you are wondering whether a community college or a four-year university is the best option for the students you are counseling, consider this passage from College Board:

“While community colleges typically offer a wide range of benefits for students, this choice may not be the best option for everyone. When weighing the choice between attending a community college and a four-year institution, ask yourself the following questions:

- **What do I want to study?**

If community college is in your future, make sure to choose a school that offers the degree program you want. These schools have a much more

diverse catalogue today, so you can find major areas of study in nearly any field.

- **What can I afford?**

When finances are tight and you don't want to graduate from college with a huge amount of student debt, community college can be a good option.

- **How important is campus life?**

One drawback at many community colleges is the lack of a campus community. Many students at community colleges are adults juggling jobs, family and school, so they rarely spend time on campus after classes are over. If campus life is an important part of the college experience for you, look for a community college that offers campus housing or plenty of extracurricular activities. These features will give you a sense of the college community you are searching for.

- **Can I get a job with an associate degree?**

According to the [American Community Colleges](#) website, the answer is a resounding "Yes!" One recent study found that Americans with associate degrees had a 24% share of "good jobs" in the economy (defined as defined as one with an annual salary of at least \$35,000 for those under age 45 and at least \$45,000 for workers age 45 and older).

- **Can I transfer to a four-year school?**

If a four-year degree is still in the back of your mind, look for a community college that has a [transfer agreement with a four-year school](#) in your area. These transfer agreements ensure you can move all your credits earned in community college toward your four-year degree program. In some cases, *counselors work with students directly to ensure the courses they take at the community college level will be the best contributors toward their eventual four-year degree program.*"

– Passage from College Board

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